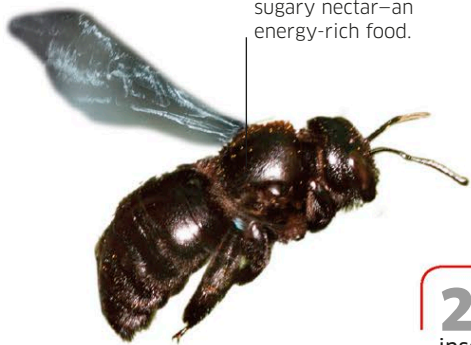


Plant reproduction

Despite being rooted in the ground, plants work hard to ensure the survival of their species. With the help of wind, water, and animals, they fertilize one another and disperse their seeds far and wide.

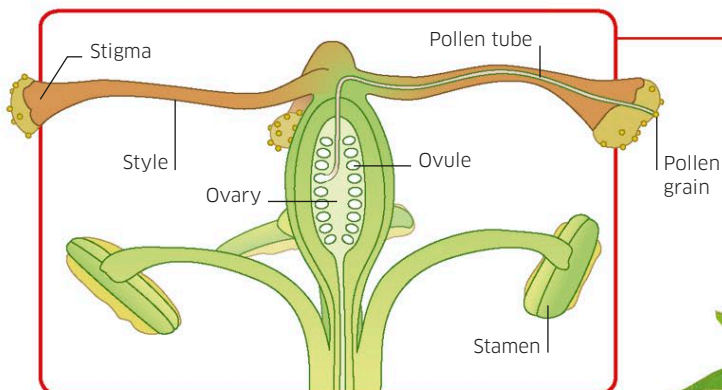
Flowers are the reproductive organs of most kinds of plants and contain both male and female cells. The male cells—encased in dusty pollen grains—fertilize eggs in the flower's female parts. Each tiny young plant produced is then enclosed inside a seed: a survival capsule that protects its contents until they are ready to germinate.

Carpenter bees visit the flowers to collect sugary nectar—an energy-rich food.



1 Flowering
The flower's vibrant purple stripes guide a carpenter bee to the nectar glands at its center. Other plants with less attractive flowers may instead scatter their pollen on the wind.

2 Pollination
Yellow stamens brush the insect's hairy body with pollen, which the bees carry with them to the purple clublike stigmas of another plant in the species.



3 Fertilization
After landing on the stigma, the pollen grains sprout microscopic tubes to carry their male cells down the style to reach the female eggs. Each fertilized egg then grows into an embryo, nestled inside a white capsule called an ovule.

Reproduction partnerships

Like many kinds of plants, the passion vine from South America relies on animals to help it reproduce. Large, hairy carpenter bees in search of sweet nectar carry pollen from flower to flower, while birds with a taste for fruit—here the great kiskadee—spread the seeds.

4 Fruiting
When fertilized, the base of the flower begins to develop into a fleshy fruit. The ovules embedded inside harden to form seeds.

Stamen
Yellow stamens, which produce dustlike pollen grains, are the male parts of the plant.

After fertilization, the petals of a flower shrivel and fall off.

